British-era settlement can just about be discerned if one goes to Mahavir Chowk, the busy marketplace in Old Gurgaon. If one looks closely enough, one can still see the remains of an old serai that would have been used by caravans heading to and from Delhi.

For the first few decades after independence, Gurgaon remained a relatively small town in a largely rural district. The first major change came when Sanjay Gandhi, son of then-Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, acquired a large plot of land to start an automobile company in the early 1970s. This is now the Maruti-Suzuki factory, but the project was not initially successful. From the early eighties, however, a number of real estate developers, particularly DLF, began to acquire farmland along the Delhi border. The idea at this stage was to build a mostly low-rise suburbia for Delhi's retiring civil servants. Although the Maruti car factory did get going by 1983, no one really envisaged Gurgaon as an independent growth engine.

The whole dynamics changed after India liberalized its economy in 1991, which coincided with the communications and information technology revolutions. As India globalized, a number of multinational companies discovered that call centres and back-office operations could be outsourced to India. Delhi was a good location for this because of available human capital and a well-connected international airport. However, the necessary real estate could not be created because of Delhi's rigid master plan. The old planners had never envisioned white-collar factories. The outsourcing companies, therefore, jumped across the border to Gurgaon and began to build huge facilities for this new industry.

This attracted young workers to Gurgaon. Many of those seeking their fortune in the newly liberalized economy were the children of civil servants, public sector employees, military officers and schoolteachers. The influx of so many young people, in turn, encouraged the construction of malls and restaurants. As this generation intermarried and set up home, the single-house format was abandoned in favour of condominiums more suited to the lifestyles of corporate executives. Schools and other educational institutions too began to multiply. The pace of expansion can be gauged from a lone milestone that survives on MG Road under the elevated Metro